

The conquest of Africa

From the 1880s, European nations began campaigns to take over large parts of Africa. They claimed they were trying to stamp out slavery in Africa, but in truth they wanted to exploit the resource-rich continent to feed the growing industries in Europe and the US.

By the 19th century, many countries in Europe had grown wealthy by using enslaved people from Africa as free labor (see pp.132–133). But as these nations became more industrialized, there was a shift in demand—instead of workers, they now needed raw materials for their factories.

Most European countries had created coastal trading posts in Africa by 1600, but 200 years later they had barely started exploring the interior of the continent. Reports of vast untapped resources in the heart of Africa resulted in a race to colonize

the land. The nations involved were Britain, Spain, France, Belgium, Italy, Portugal, and Germany. Each tried to grab lands through pacts with local chiefs or kings, battling other colonial armies, or forcing native communities off their lands.

At the time, Africa was home to more than 10,000 different states and societies, and the colonists were met with fierce opposition. Countless battles ensued over the last quarter of the 19th century. However, by 1900, most the continent was under the control of colonial powers.



▲ BATTLE OF ISANDLWANA

In January 1879, the British began their invasion of Zululand in southern Africa. Zulu warriors armed with iron spears, cow-hide shields (above), and just a few rifles crushed the British in the Battle of Isandlwana. The British forces had suffered their worst defeat against an Indigenous force, but six months later, they returned to defeat the Zulu Kingdom, turning the region into a colony.



FACT

In 1884, Anglo-American inventor Hiram Stevens Maxim created the first automatic machine gun—the Maxim gun. It played a major role in the colonial invasion of Africa.

◀ COLONIAL EMPIRES OF AFRICA

By the end of the 19th century, most of Africa was under European rule. France, Britain, Germany, Belgium, Portugal, Italy, and Spain had each claimed regions for themselves. Britain and France controlled the largest portions of the continent.